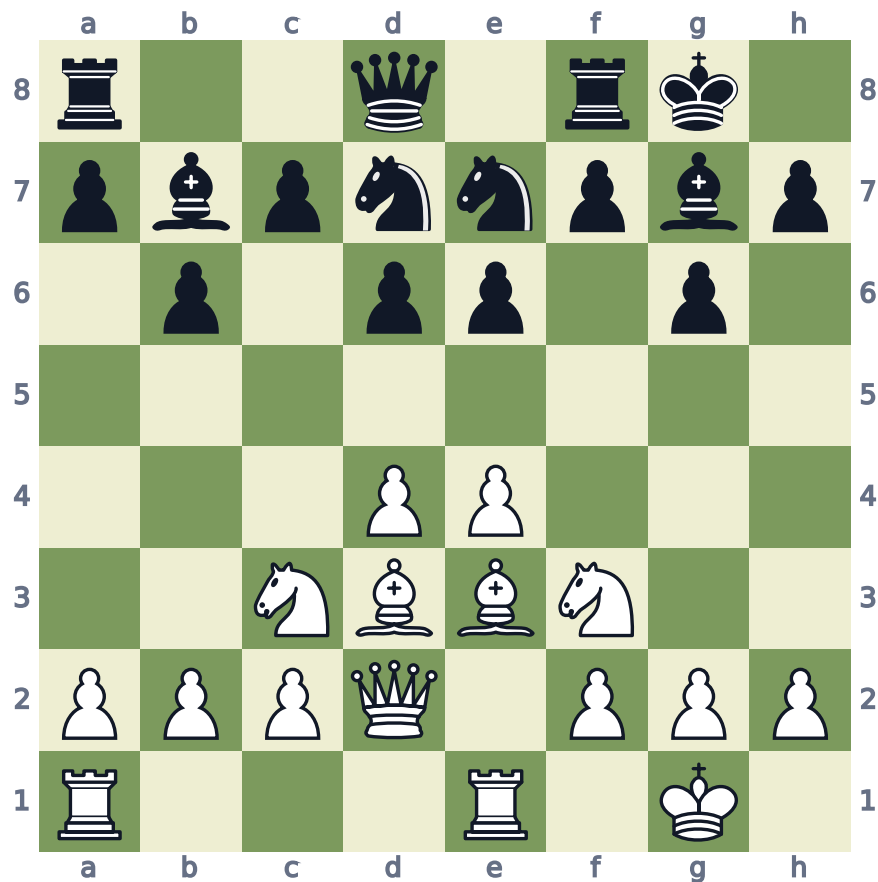


Hippo Pawn-Structure and Plan Atlas

Thirty recurring structures, breaks, files, outposts, and piece-placement rules



Connect the opening shell to the middlegame structures that actually determine plans, so unfamiliar move orders still feel understandable.

30 learning units | solid-piece diagrams | recall tests | engine checks

ORIENTATION

How to study this volume

PURPOSE

Connect the opening shell to the middlegame structures that actually determine plans, so unfamiliar move orders still feel understandable.

THE HIPPO TRAINING LOOP

- First identify the center, both kings, and the opponent's most forcing pawn break.
- At every diagram, name the urgent threat and compare e5, c5, f5, and b5.
- Hide the answer until you have spoken the move, its purpose, and the opponent's best reply.
- Replay each branch from both sides in Fritz or another board program.
- Review misses after 1, 3, 7, 14, 30, and 60 days.
-

WHAT COMPLETE MEANS HERE

This volume contains 30 units inside a connected Black core repertoire. It teaches setup, exceptions, transformation, and resulting plans; the PGN companions make later updating possible.

STRATEGIC FOUNDATION

Principles 1-3

PRINCIPLE 1

The pawn structure is the Hippo's decision engine.

PRINCIPLE 2

Every break opens lines while surrendering squares.

PRINCIPLE 3

Closed centers require a second break and a useful maneuvering route.

VERIFICATION QUESTION

What would have to be true for one of these principles to be wrong in the current position? Check forcing moves before applying a strategic rule.

STRATEGIC FOUNDATION

Principles 4-6

PRINCIPLE 4

An open diagonal matters only when a target sits on it.

PRINCIPLE 5

The least active piece often identifies the next preparatory move.

PRINCIPLE 6

Structure knowledge replaces fragile memorization with transferable judgment.

VERIFICATION QUESTION

What would have to be true for one of these principles to be wrong in the current position? Check forcing moves before applying a strategic rule.

STRUCTURE CHECKLIST

Read the pawns before choosing a plan

1. CENTER

Is it open, closed, fixed, mobile, or under immediate tension?

2. PAWN BREAKS

Which pawn move can change the structure, and what squares will it abandon?

3. FILES

Which files will open after the likely exchanges?

4. OUTPOSTS

Which squares cannot be challenged by an enemy pawn?

5. BAD PIECE

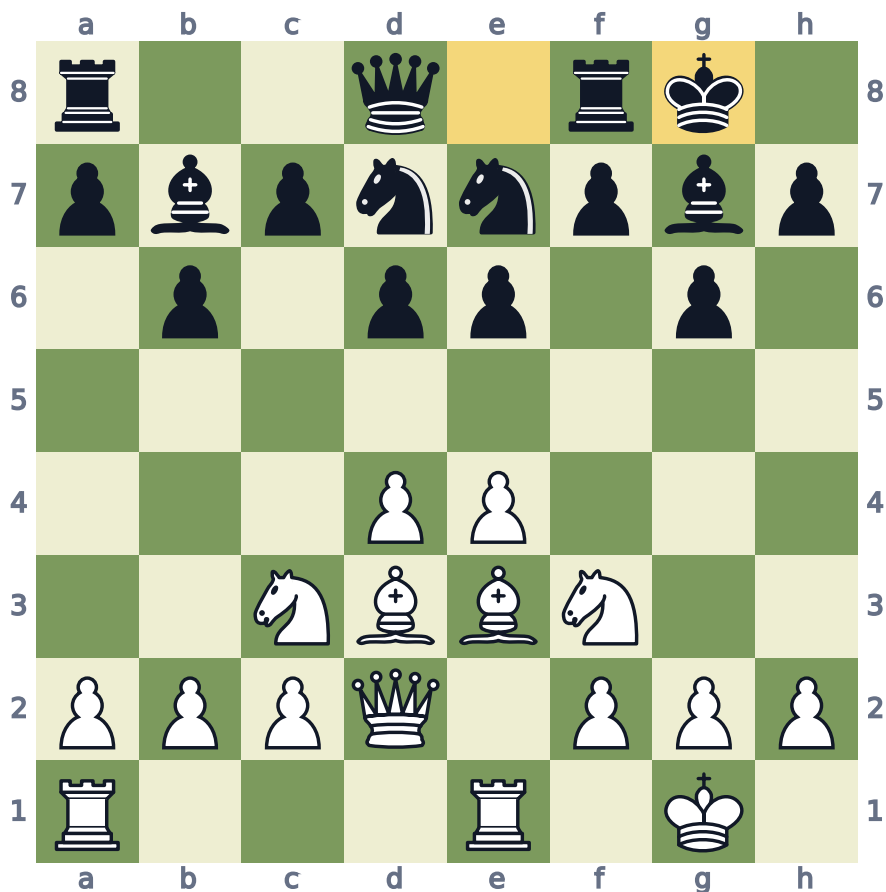
Which piece has the fewest useful squares, and what pawn move would improve it?

6. WING

Which side of the board does the pawn chain point toward?

STRUCTURE 01 OF 30

Classical center with Nf3 and Bd3



COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Finish development while preparing the break that attacks White's less-supported center pawn.

OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

White may play Bh6, e5, or h4 before Black is fully ready.

ENGINE SAMPLE

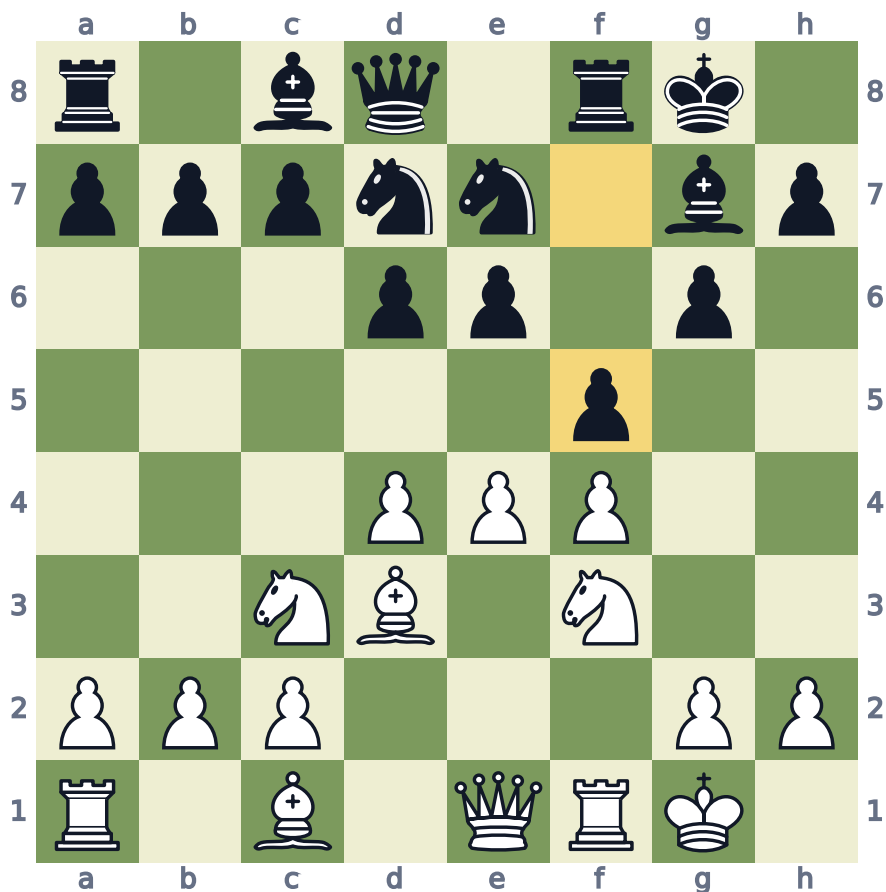
1. Rad1 Kh8 2. Bg5 f6 3. Be3 Ng8 4. h4 a6 5. a4 (+0.99 for White (White is clearly better))

TRANSFER CUE

The classical center gives time only if every move prepares contact.

STRUCTURE 02 OF 30

Austrian center and f5 counterstrike



COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Challenge e4 before White's e5-f5 expansion takes over the kingside.

OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

exf5 can open lines against Black's king and e6.

ENGINE SAMPLE

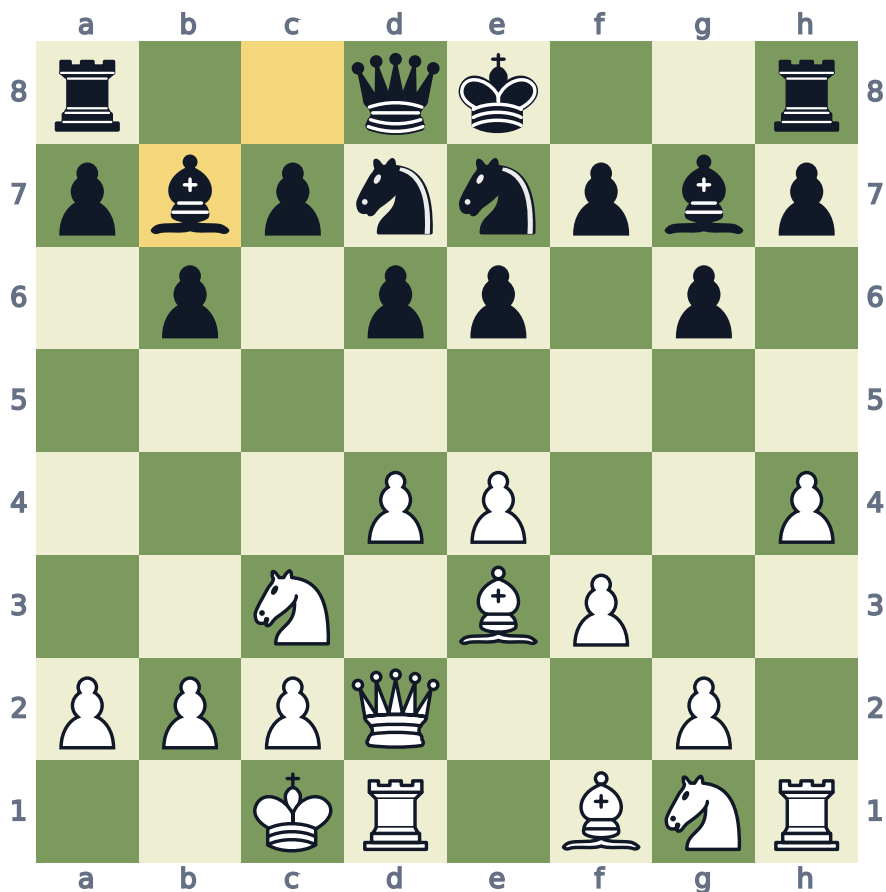
1. h3 Nb6 2. e5 Bd7 3. a4 Bc6 4. a5 Nbd5 5. Ng5 (+1.28 for White (White is clearly better))

TRANSFER CUE

Against f4, f5 is thematic only after king safety and piece support are checked.

STRUCTURE 03 OF 30

150 Attack style development



COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Delay castling, develop the queenside bishop, and create counterplay against the long-castled king.

OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

h5 can open the g-file while Black is still compact.

ENGINE SAMPLE

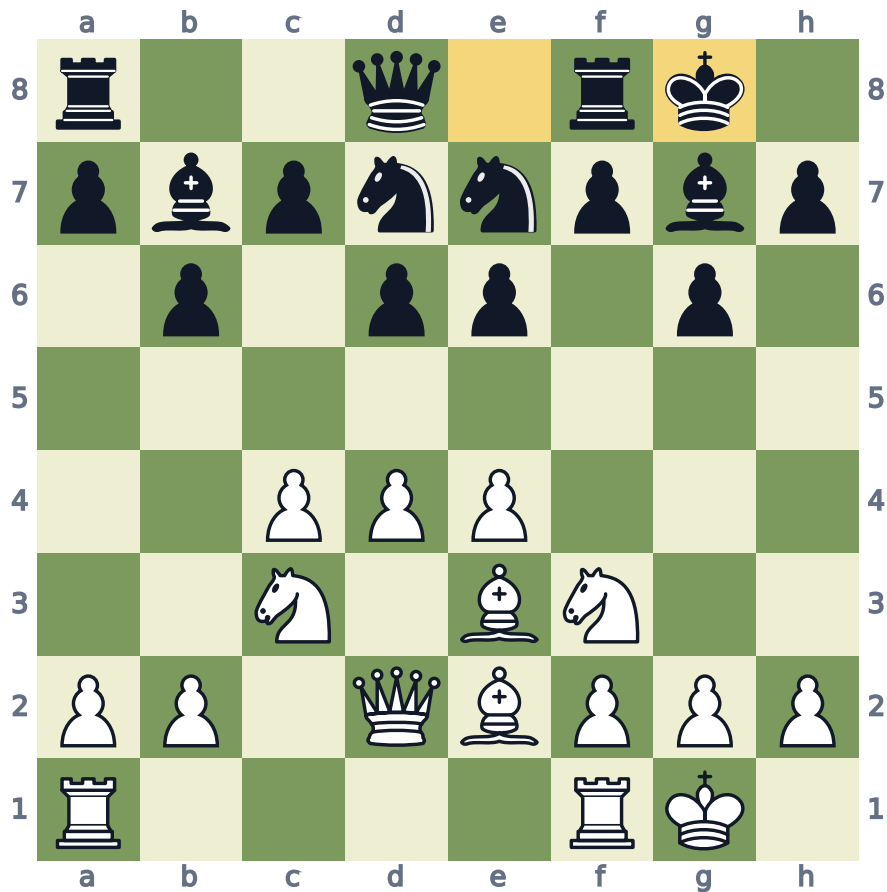
1. h5 h6 2. hxg6 Nxg6 3. Bxh6 Rxh6 4. Rxh6 Bxh6 5. Qxh6 a6 (+1.66 for White (White is clearly better))

TRANSFER CUE

Qd2 and long castling move the target; answer on the queenside or in the center.

STRUCTURE 04 OF 30

Classical Queen's Pawn center



COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Complete the shell and prepare c5 or e5 against the broad center.

OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

d5 can gain space and restrict both knights.

ENGINE SAMPLE

1. Rad1 Nf6 2. d5 e5 3. Ne1 Bc8 (+1.06 for White (White is clearly better))

TRANSFER CUE

Against c4-d4-e4, attack the base before White fixes it.

STRUCTURE 05 OF 30

London System



COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Develop without chasing Bf4 and prepare e5 or c5 against d4.

OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

White may build e4 with Nbd2 and c3 if Black waits.

ENGINE SAMPLE

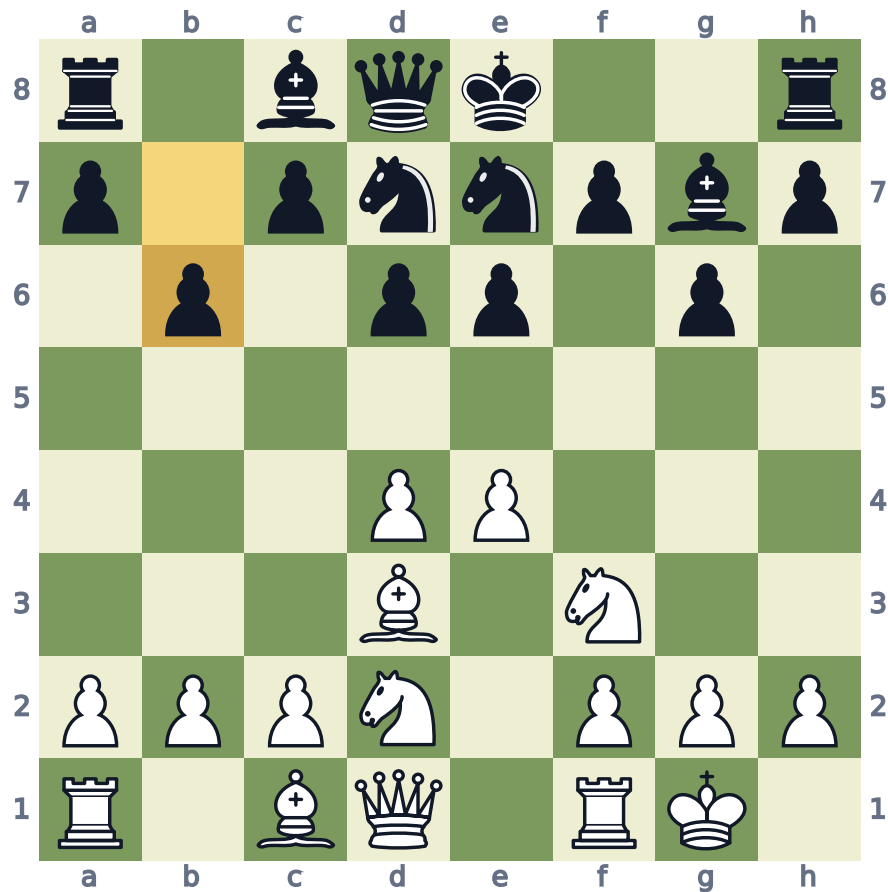
1. c4 O-O 2. Nc3 e5 3. dxe5 Nxe5 4. Nxe5 dxe5 (+0.64 for White (White is slightly better))

TRANSFER CUE

The London bishop is not the center; challenge d4 and e4.

STRUCTURE 06 OF 30

Colle System



COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Use White's modest setup to complete development before central contact.

OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

e5 can arrive with a strong kingside attack if Black remains passive.

ENGINE SAMPLE

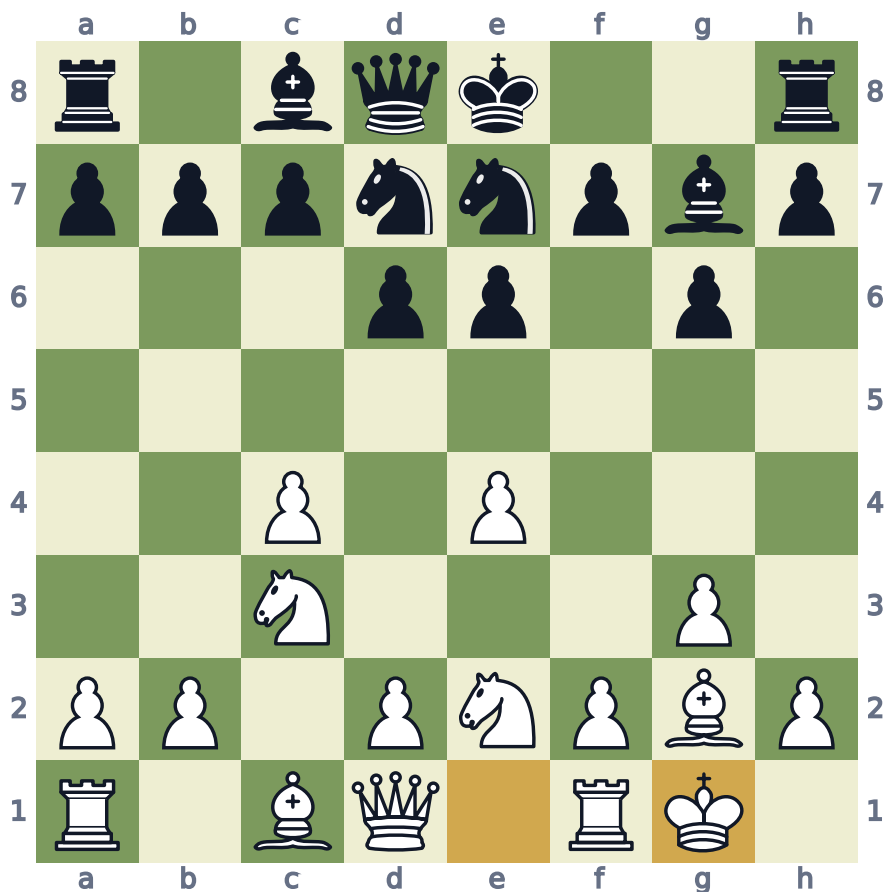
1. Re1 O-O 2. c3 c5 3. Nf1 cxd4 4. cxd4 (+0.74 for White (White is slightly better))

TRANSFER CUE

Extra setup time is a resource only when it is invested in a break.

STRUCTURE 07 OF 30

English fianchetto



COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Transpose to a Hippo after White occupies e4 and prepare c5 or e5.

OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

White can play d4 in one move and obtain a large center.

ENGINE SAMPLE

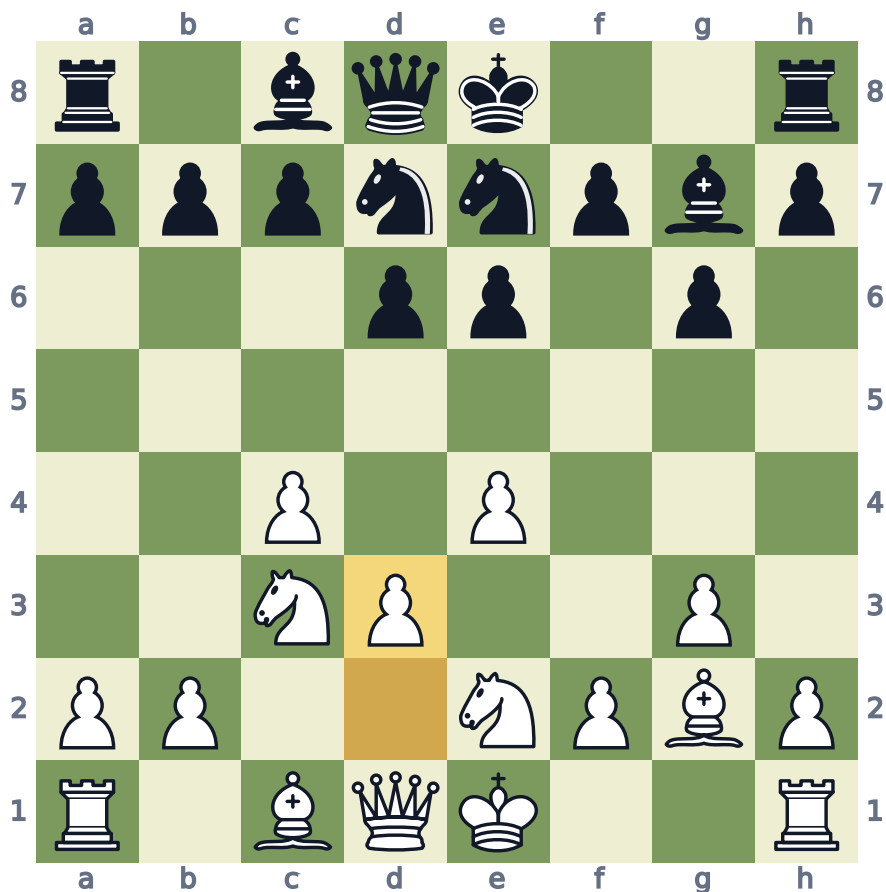
1. a6 d4 2. Rb8 a4 3. O-O b4 4. Nc6 Rb1 5. e5 Be3
(+0.62 for White (White is slightly better))

TRANSFER CUE

The English label disappears once e4 arrives; read the pawns.

STRUCTURE 08 OF 30

Botvinnik English setup



COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Restrict d4, develop compactly, and aim for f5 or c5.

OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

White may use f4-f5 with extra tempo.

ENGINE SAMPLE

1. a6 a4 2. c5 d4 3. cxd4 Nxd4 4. Qc7 O-O 5. Qxc4 Be3 (+0.26 for White (White is slightly better))

TRANSFER CUE

Against pawns on c4 and e4, control d4 and identify the correct wing.

STRUCTURE 09 OF 30

Reti with e4



COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Maintain flexibility until e4 identifies a familiar Hippo center.

OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

d4 and c4 can still expand before Black makes contact.

ENGINE SAMPLE

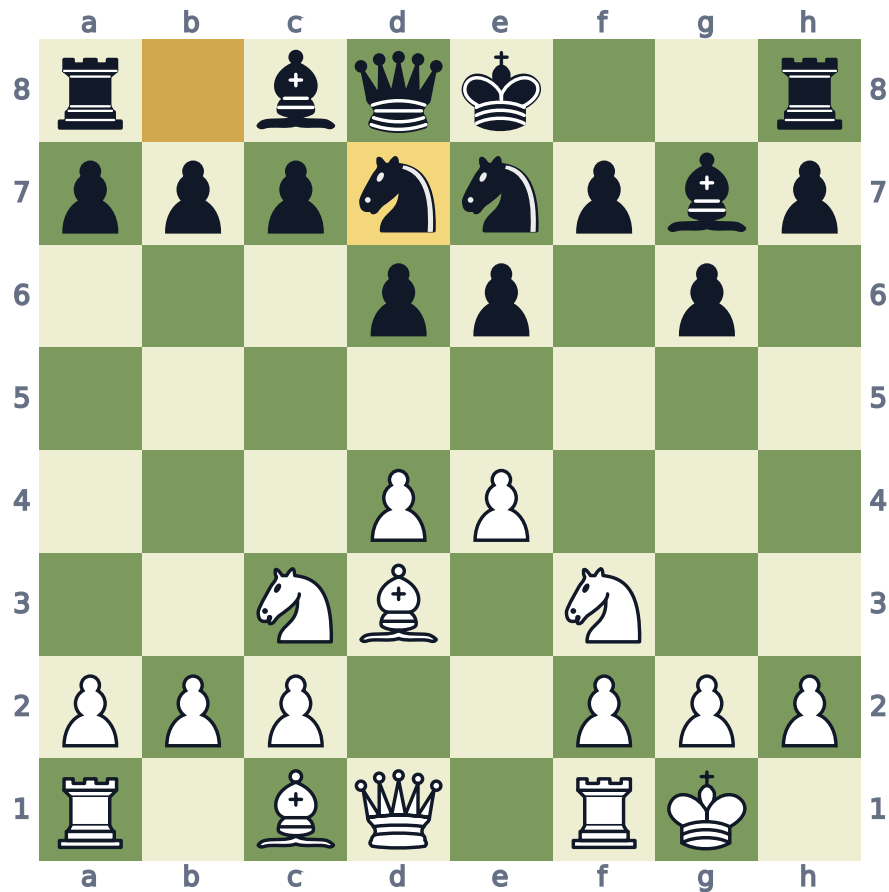
1. a4 e5 2. Nc3 a6 3. Be3 (+0.48 for White (White is slightly better))

TRANSFER CUE

Transpose by position, not by the first-move name.

STRUCTURE 10 OF 30

1...d6 first against e4



COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Use d6 to discourage some early e5 tactics, then transpose into the shell.

OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

White may choose f4 before Black completes development.

ENGINE SAMPLE

1. Bg5 a6 2. Qd2 h6 3. Be3 b6 4. Rfd1 Bb7 5. a4 Nf6 (+0.80 for White (White is clearly better))

TRANSFER CUE

d6 first changes options, not the final structure.

STRUCTURE 11 OF 30

1...d6 first against d4



COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Keep the move order compact while reading White's center.

OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

e5 or d5 can gain space before Black finishes.

ENGINE SAMPLE

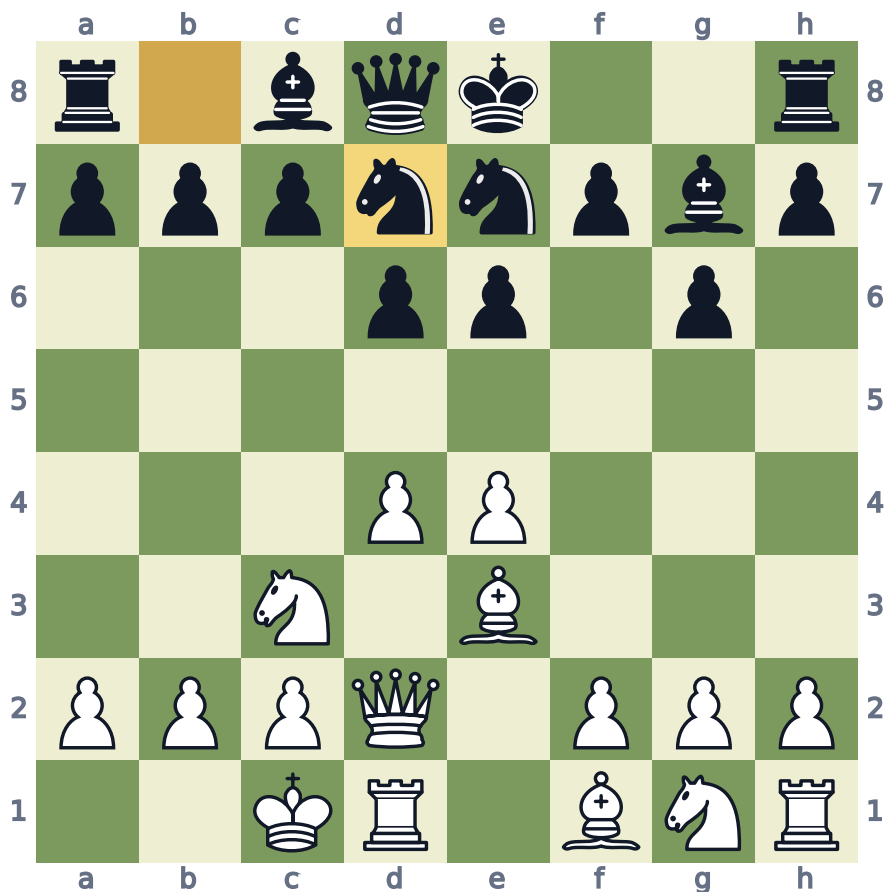
1. Be3 O-O 2. h4 e5 3. h5 exd4 4. Nxd4 Nbc6 5. Qd2 Nxd4 (+1.18 for White (White is clearly better))

TRANSFER CUE

Reach the shell with the order that removes the opponent's most forcing option.

STRUCTURE 12 OF 30

Delay d6 until the center appears



COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Preserve transpositions, then choose d6 once White shows e4-d4.

OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

White's h4 can force king-safety decisions immediately.

ENGINE SAMPLE

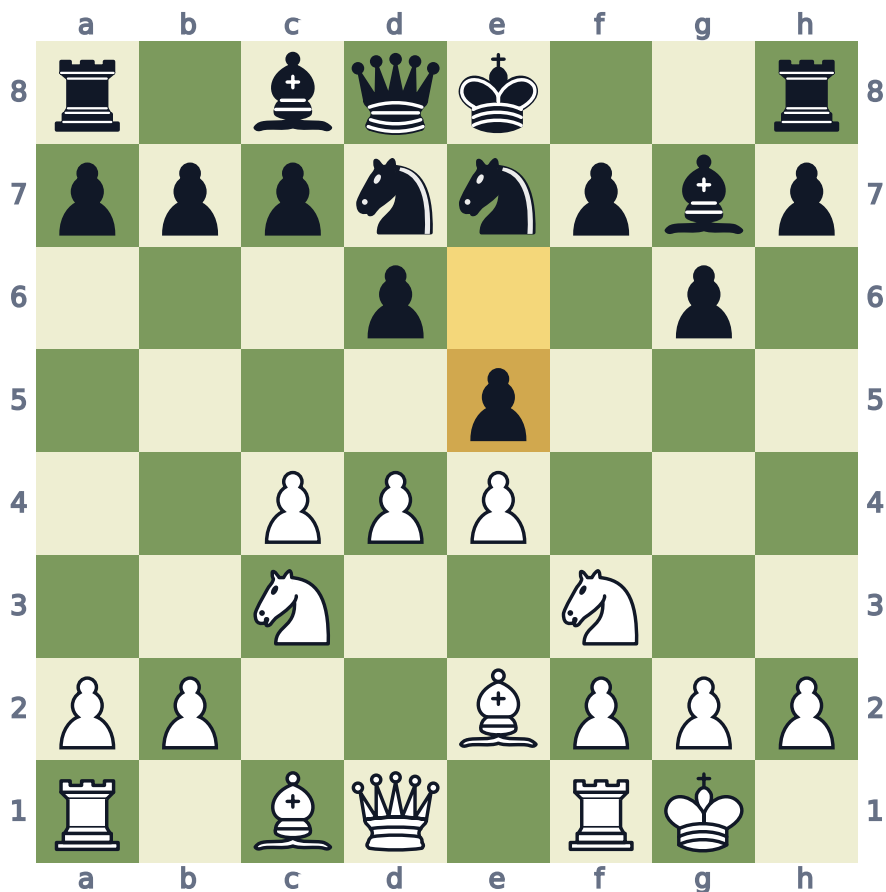
1. Bh6 Bxh6 2. Qxh6 a6 3. Qg7 Rf8 4. Nh3 (+1.39 for White (White is clearly better))

TRANSFER CUE

Flexibility has value only until the opponent makes a threat.

STRUCTURE 13 OF 30

e5 against the classical d4 center



COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Attack d4, free the queen and knights, and force White to define the center.

OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

d5 gains space and can leave Black's pieces short of squares.

ENGINE SAMPLE

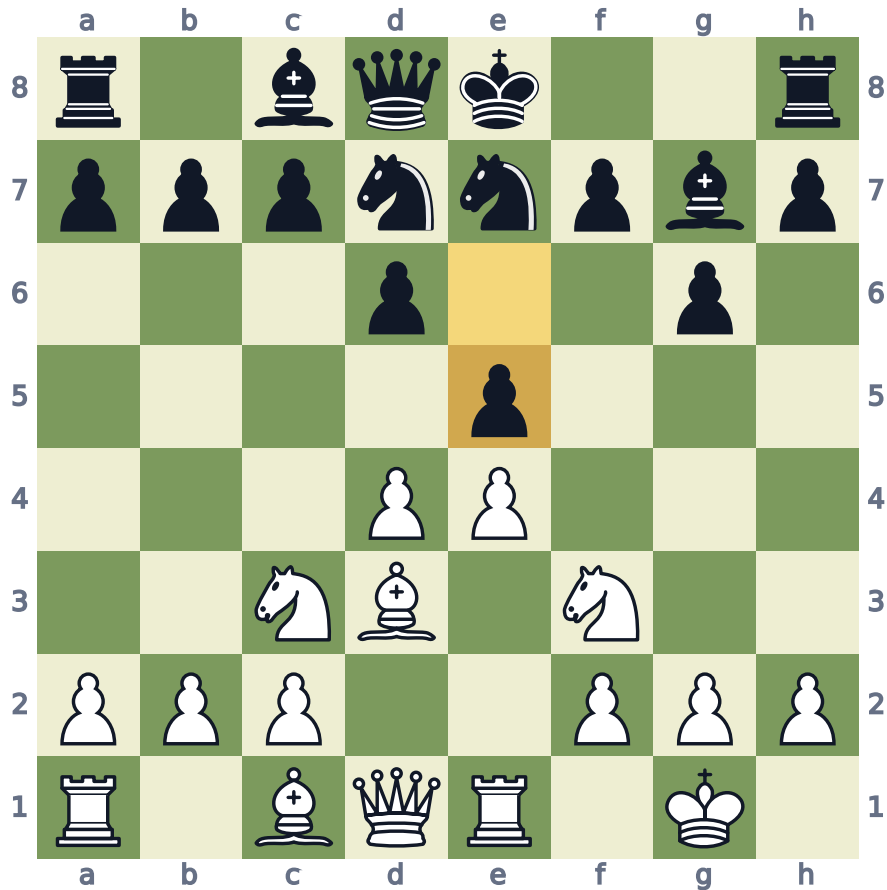
1. dxe5 Nxe5 2. Nxe5 Bxe5 3. Be3 Bxc3 4. bxc3 Nc6 5. Bh6 Qh4 (+1.33 for White (White is clearly better))

TRANSFER CUE

Before e5, calculate d5, dxe5, and the tension-maintaining reply.

STRUCTURE 14 OF 30

e5 against a rook on e1



COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Challenge d4 while using piece support to survive e-file tactics.

OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

dx e5 can expose the rook against the e-pawn or queen.

ENGINE SAMPLE

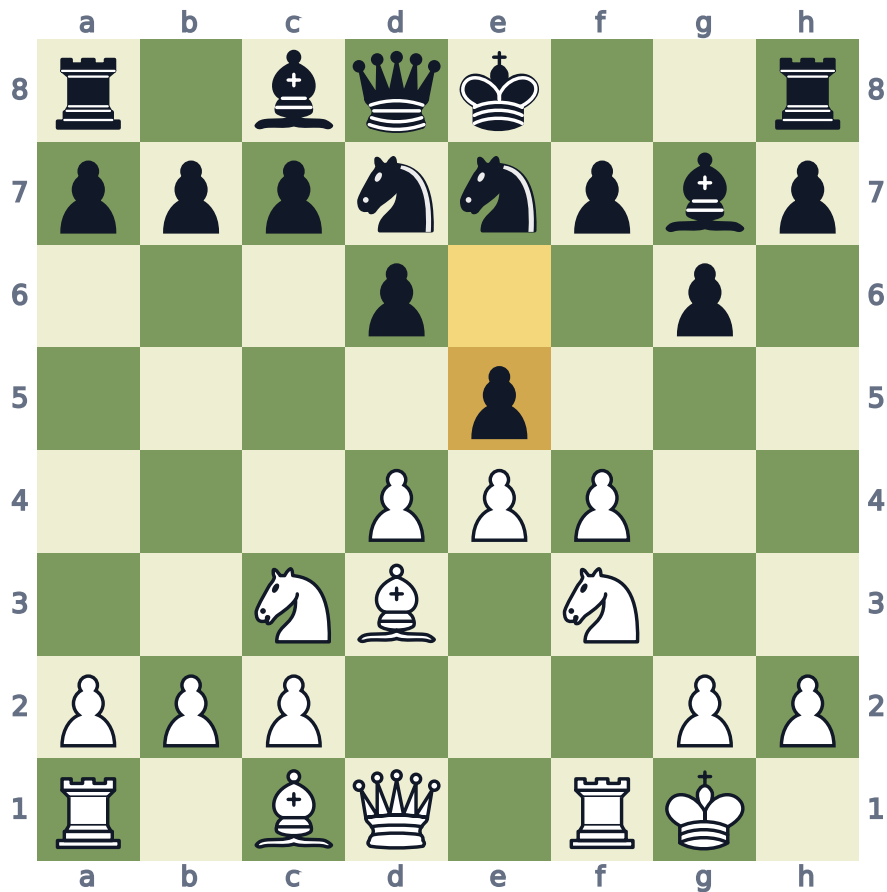
1. dx e5 Nx e5 2. Nx e5 dx e5 3. Bc4 Qxd1 4. Rxd1 c6 (+1.17 for White (White is clearly better))

TRANSFER CUE

A rook on e1 makes the break more tactical, not automatically bad.

STRUCTURE 15 OF 30

e5 against the Austrian center



COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Hit d4 before White advances e5 and f5.

OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

fxe5 can open the f-file and leave e6 sensitive.

ENGINE SAMPLE

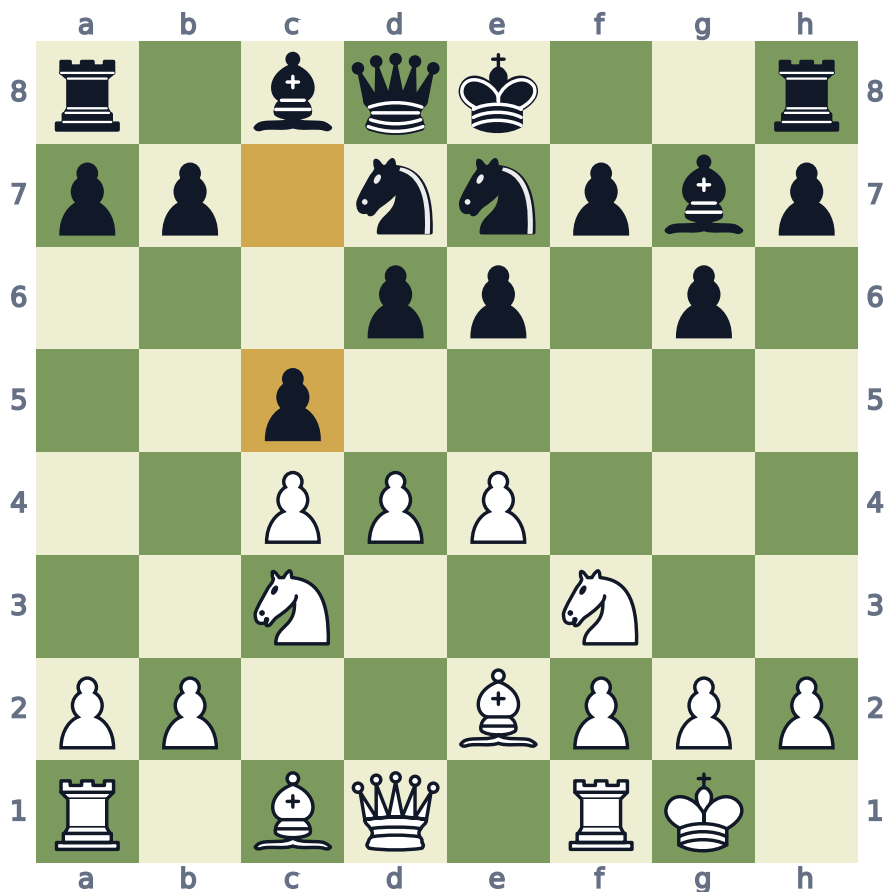
1. fxe5 O-O 2. exd6 cxd6 3. a4 Nf6 4. Qe1 h6 (+2.52 for White (White is clearly better))

TRANSFER CUE

Against f4, e5 is a race against White's own e5 push.

STRUCTURE 16 OF 30

c5 against the broad d4 center



COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Attack d4 and open a queenside route for the rook and queen.

OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

d5 can gain a Benoni-style space advantage.

ENGINE SAMPLE

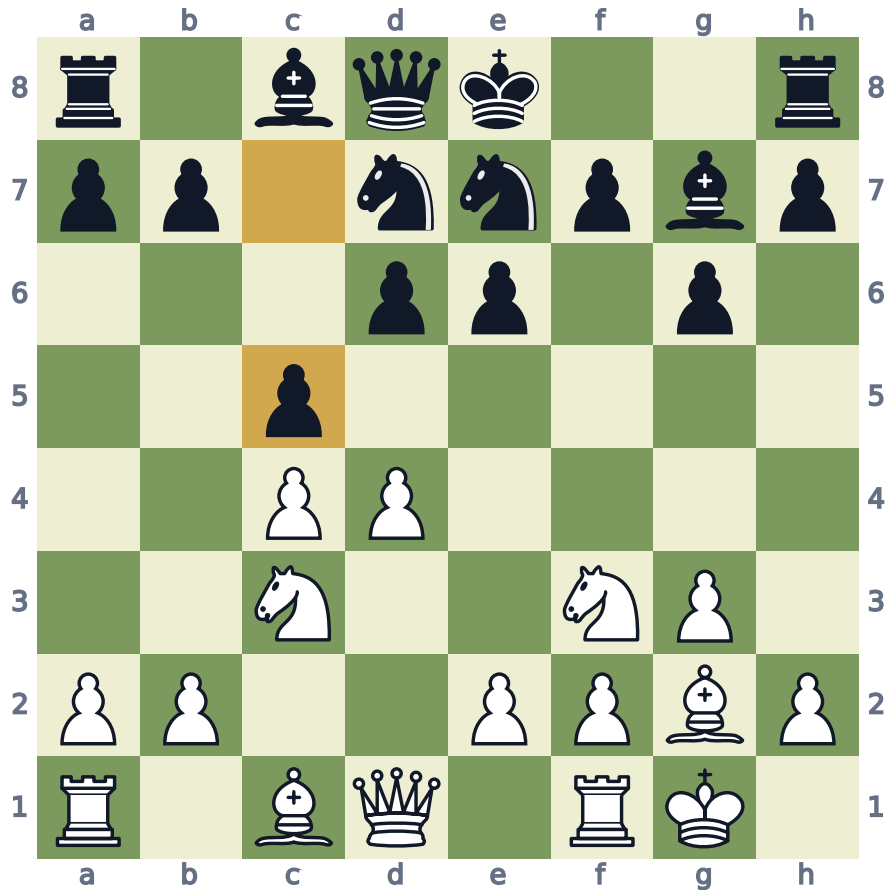
1. Nb5 O-O 2. Nxd6 Qb6 3. dxc5 Nxc5 4. Rb1 a5 5. e5
(+1.60 for White (White is clearly better))

TRANSFER CUE

c5 asks the base of the center a direct question.

STRUCTURE 17 OF 30

c5 in a double-fianchetto position



COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Challenge d4 while both bishops point toward the center.

OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

d5 can close Bg7 and give White a protected queenside chain.

ENGINE SAMPLE

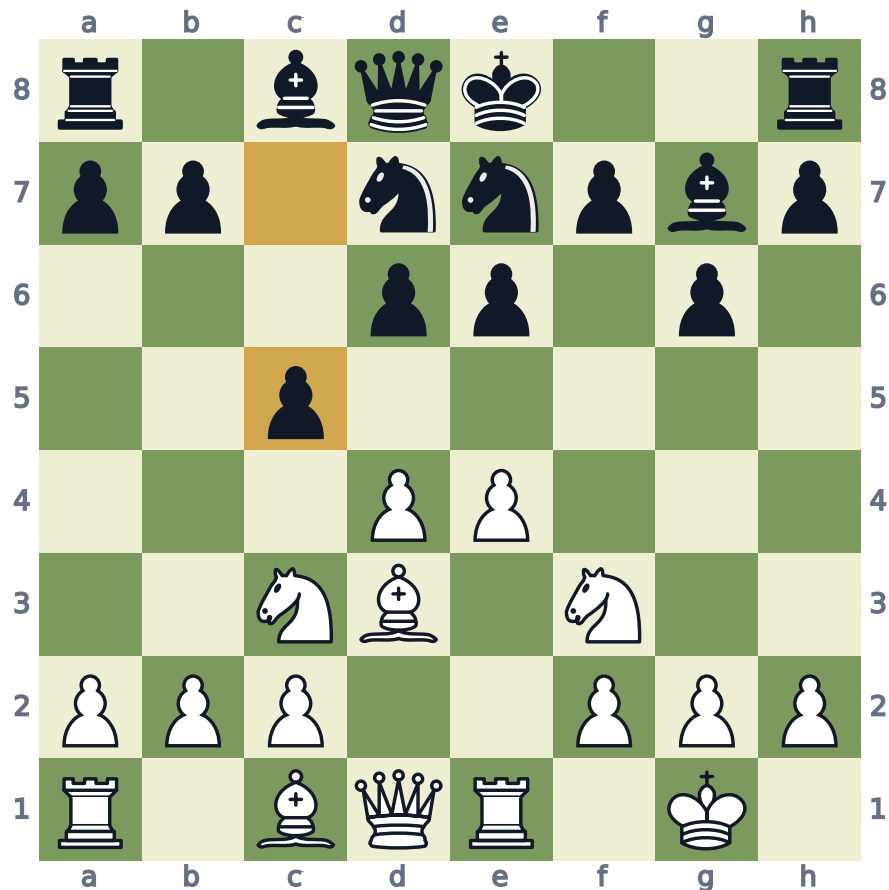
1. Ne4 O-O 2. Nxd6 Qb6 3. Nxc8 Raxc8 4. d5 exd5 5. cxd5 Nf6 (+1.33 for White (White is clearly better))

TRANSFER CUE

In fianchetto structures, the first useful diagonal often appears after c5.

STRUCTURE 18 OF 30

c5 against the classical e4 center



COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Pressure d4 and invite a structure Black can attack on the c-file.

OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

d5 may gain space and support e5.

ENGINE SAMPLE

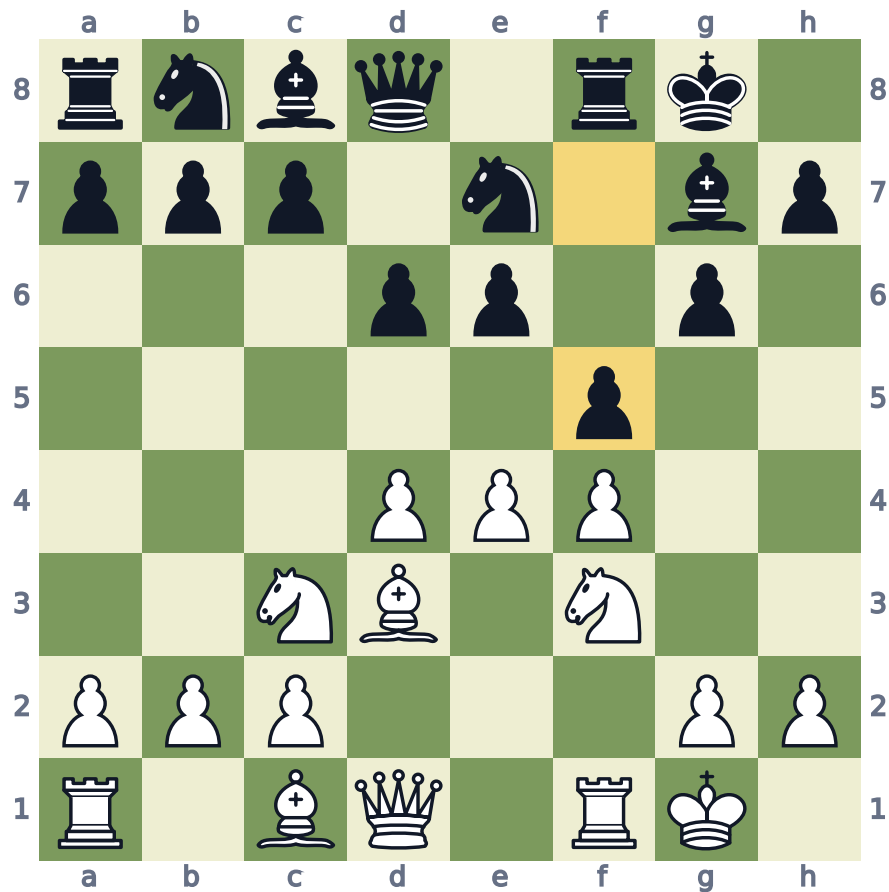
1. dxc5 dxc5 2. e5 O-O 3. h4 b6 4. Bf4 Bb7 5. Be4 Bxe4 (+1.31 for White (White is clearly better))

TRANSFER CUE

Choose c5 when d4 is less stable than e4.

STRUCTURE 19 OF 30

f5 against the Austrian center



COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Attack e4 and contest the kingside before White plays f5.

OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

exf5 can expose Black's king and the e6 pawn.

ENGINE SAMPLE

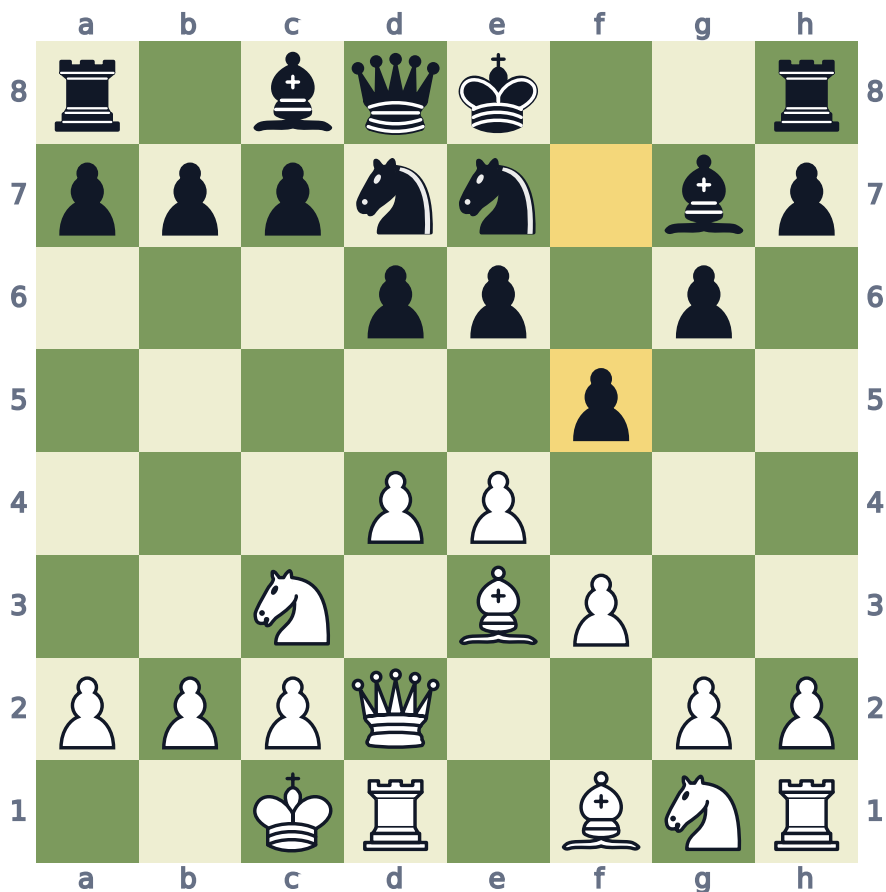
1. e5 a6 2. a4 Nbc6 3. Be3 Nb4 (+0.95 for White (White is clearly better))

TRANSFER CUE

The f-pawn is a lever, not a shield; calculate the opened file.

STRUCTURE 20 OF 30

f5 against long-castle preparation



COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Challenge e4 while White's king is headed away from the f-file.

OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

h4-h5 may arrive before Black creates queenside counterplay.

ENGINE SAMPLE

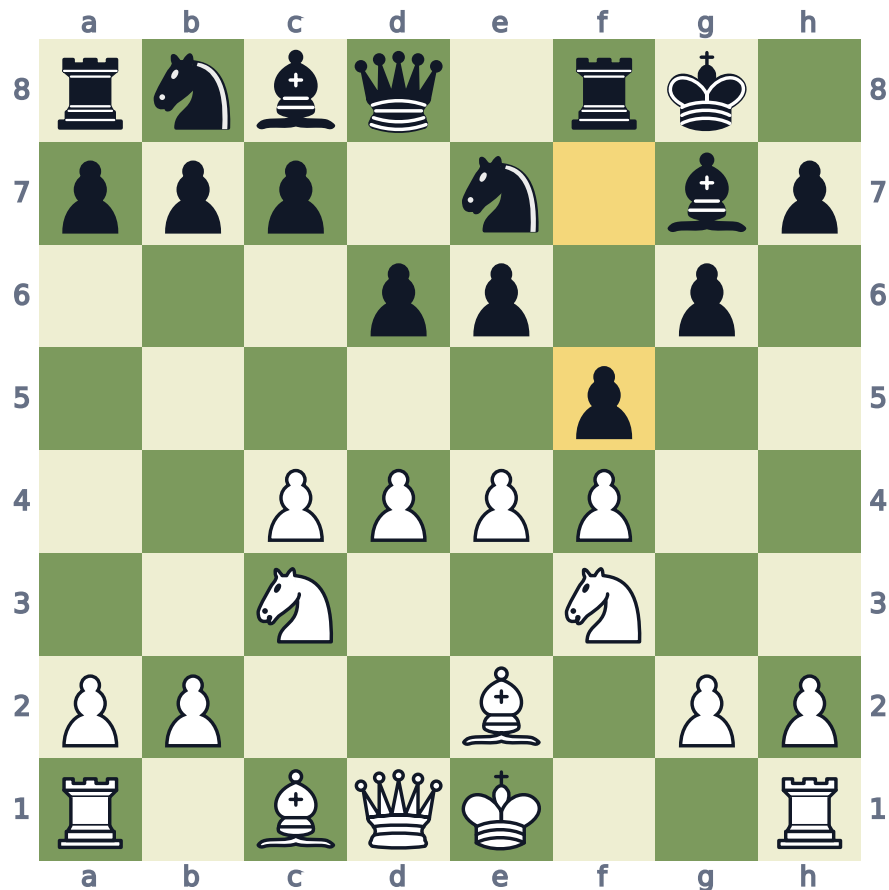
1. h4 Nf6 2. Bd3 a6 3. Nh3 b5 4. e5 Nfd5 5. Nxd5 Nxd5 (+2.01 for White (White is clearly better))

TRANSFER CUE

White's king location can make f5 safer but does not remove central tactics.

STRUCTURE 21 OF 30

f5 against a four-pawn center



COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Break the e4-f4 chain before White advances both pawns.

OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

e5 can close the position and gain kingside space.

ENGINE SAMPLE

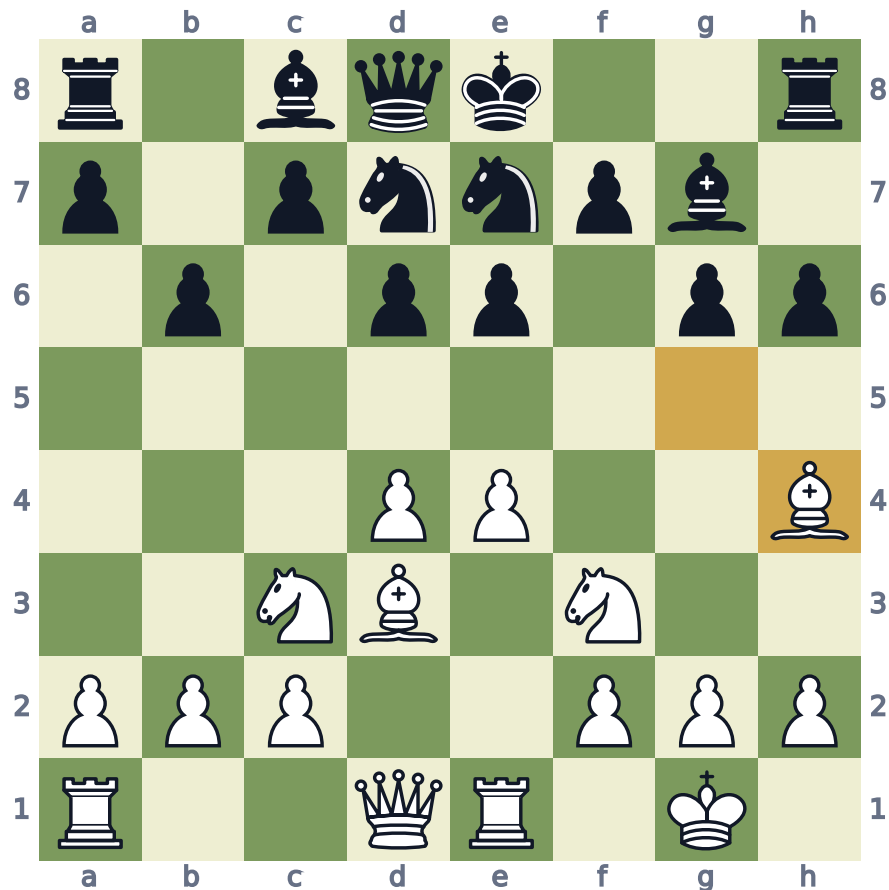
1. e5 dxe5 2. fxe5 c5 3. d5 Nd7 4. Bf4 Nb6 5. d6 Nc6
(+1.06 for White (White is clearly better))

TRANSFER CUE

Attack the chain before it moves; afterwards the target may disappear.

STRUCTURE 22 OF 30

Reroute the e7 knight



COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Use h6 to ask the bishop a question and prepare a knight route to f5 or g6.

OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

g5 can weaken the king and trap Black's own pieces.

ENGINE SAMPLE

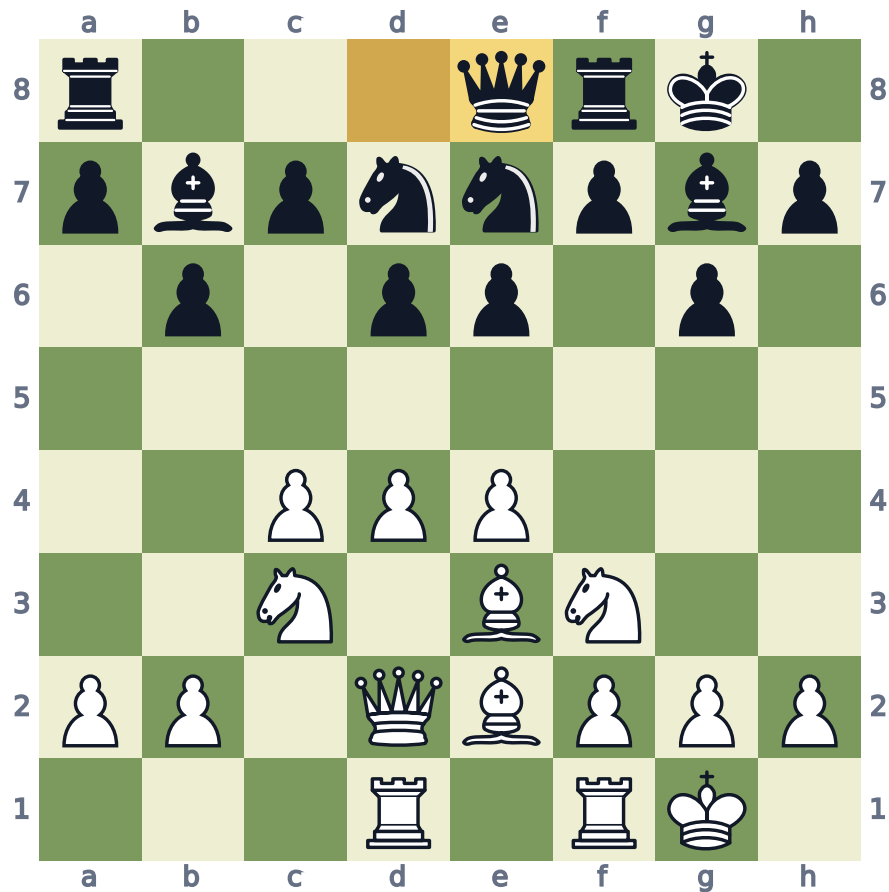
1. Bb7 Bg3 2. O-O Qe2 3. a6 Rad1 4. b5 e5 5. dxe5 dxe5 (+0.39 for White (White is slightly better))

TRANSFER CUE

The e7 knight needs a destination chosen by the break, not by habit.

STRUCTURE 23 OF 30

Queen on e8 behind e5 or f5



COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Connect the rooks and support e5 or f5 while keeping d8 available.

OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

The queen can become exposed on the e-file after exchanges.

ENGINE SAMPLE

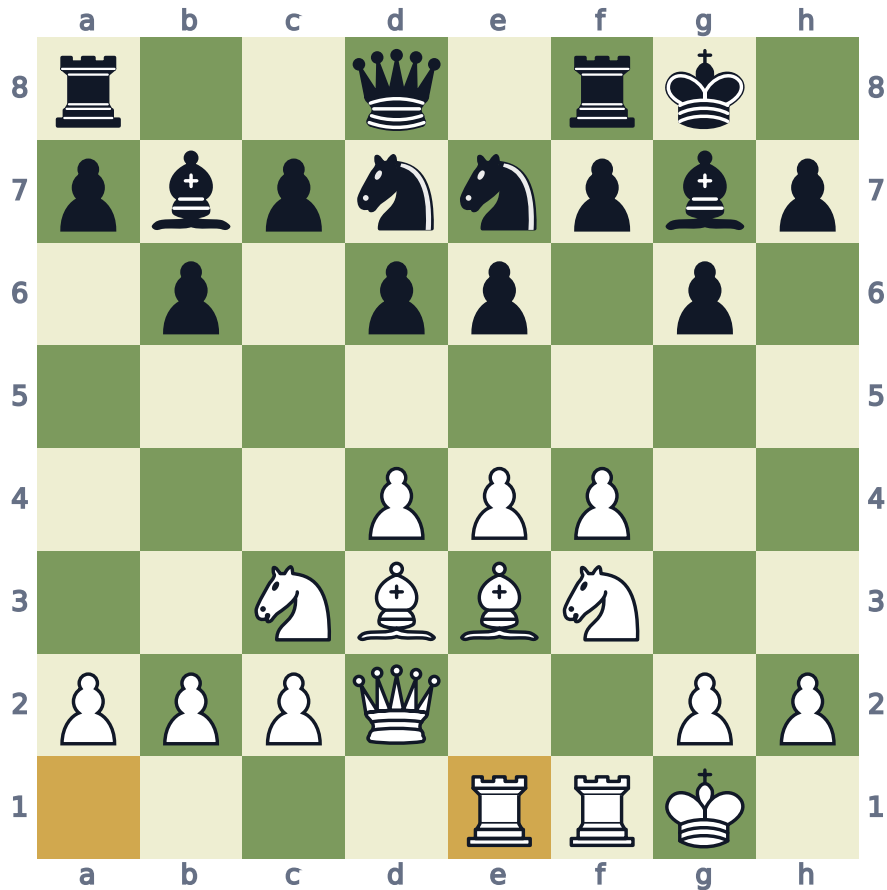
1. h3 a6 2. Rfe1 e5 (+1.34 for White (White is clearly better))

TRANSFER CUE

Qe8 is useful when it supports two plans and does not obstruct the rook.

STRUCTURE 24 OF 30

Rook behind the e-pawn



COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Put a rook behind the central contact point and increase the force of e5 ideas.

OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

The a-rook move may leave the queenside underdefended.

ENGINE SAMPLE

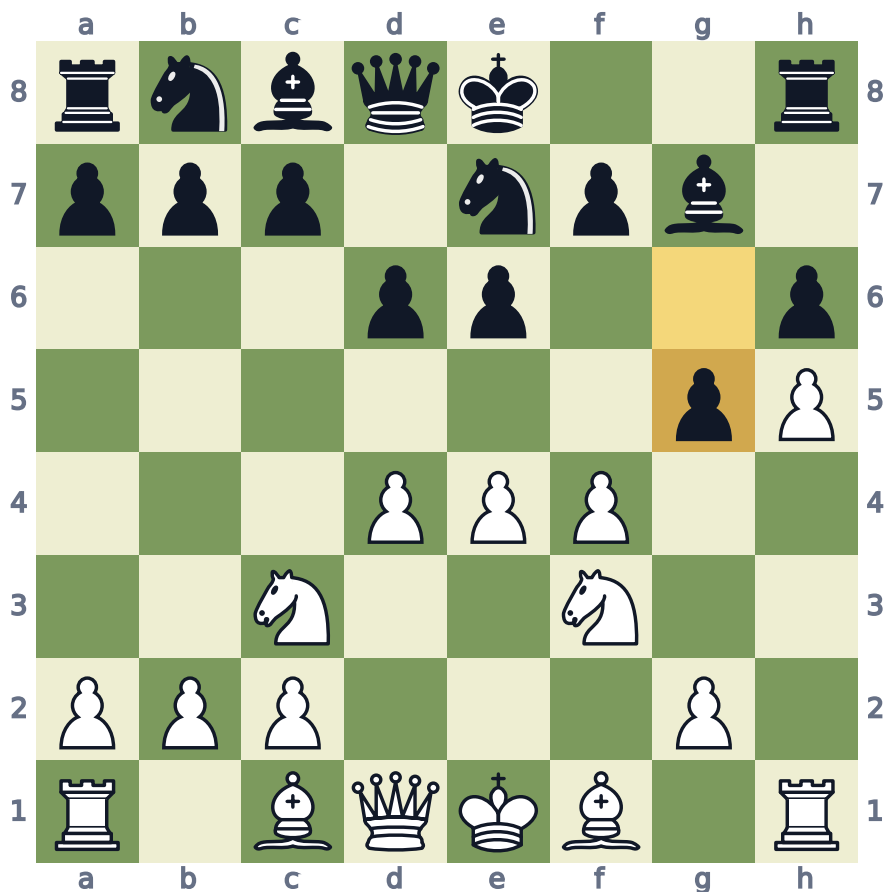
1. c5 b3 2. cxd4 Nxd4 3. Nf6 f5 4. e5 Nde2 (+0.56 for White (White is slightly better))

TRANSFER CUE

A rook belongs behind the file your break is likely to open.

STRUCTURE 25 OF 30

Close the h-file attack carefully



COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Block immediate hxg6 ideas and prepare a central counterbreak.

OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

g5 creates permanent dark-square holes and may be undermined by e5.

ENGINE SAMPLE

1. fxg5 Ng8 2. Be3 Nc6 3. Qd2 hxg5 4. Bxg5 f6 5. Be3 Nh6 (+2.97 for White (White is clearly better))

TRANSFER CUE

Closing a wing buys time; spend it on the center.

STRUCTURE 26 OF 30

Answer g4 with d5



COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Open the center while White's king and pieces lag behind the pawn storm.

OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

e5 can close the position and maintain the space advantage.

ENGINE SAMPLE

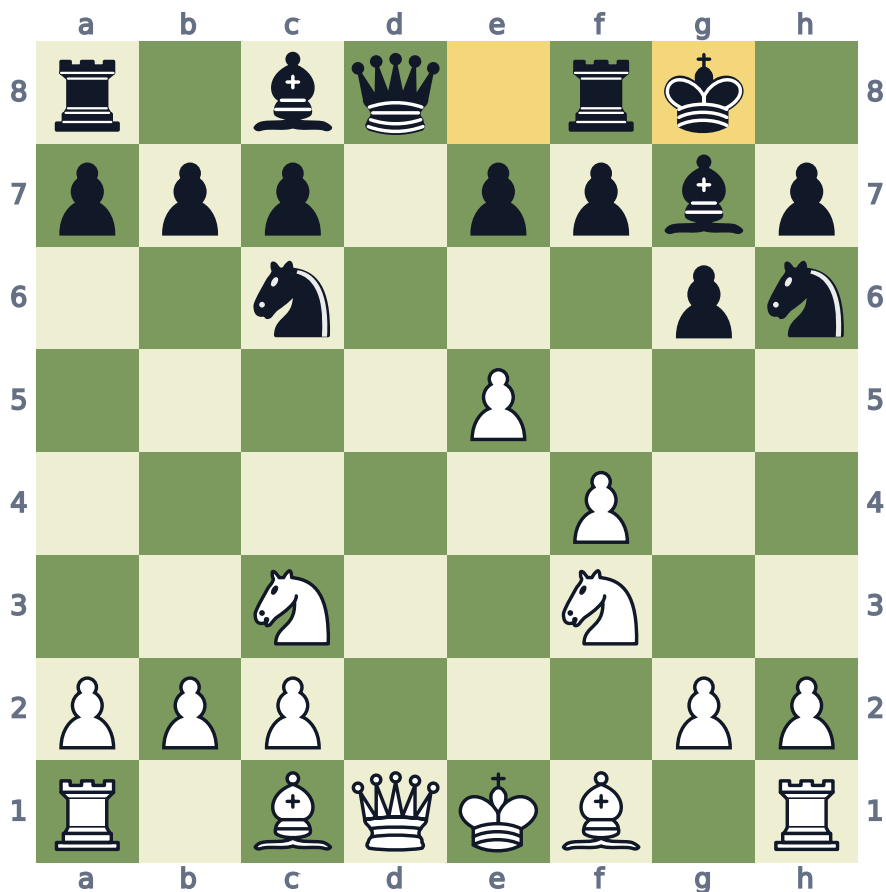
1. e5 h5 2. gxh5 Rxd5 3. h4 Bd7 4. Bd3 Nbc6 5. Bd2 Nb4 (+0.83 for White (White is clearly better))

TRANSFER CUE

A wing pawn move is a tempo you may use for central contact.

STRUCTURE 27 OF 30

Emergency reaction to e5



COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Attack or exchange the advanced pawn before it freezes the shell.

OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

Nxe5 tactics may fail if the knight is pinned or underdefended.

ENGINE SAMPLE

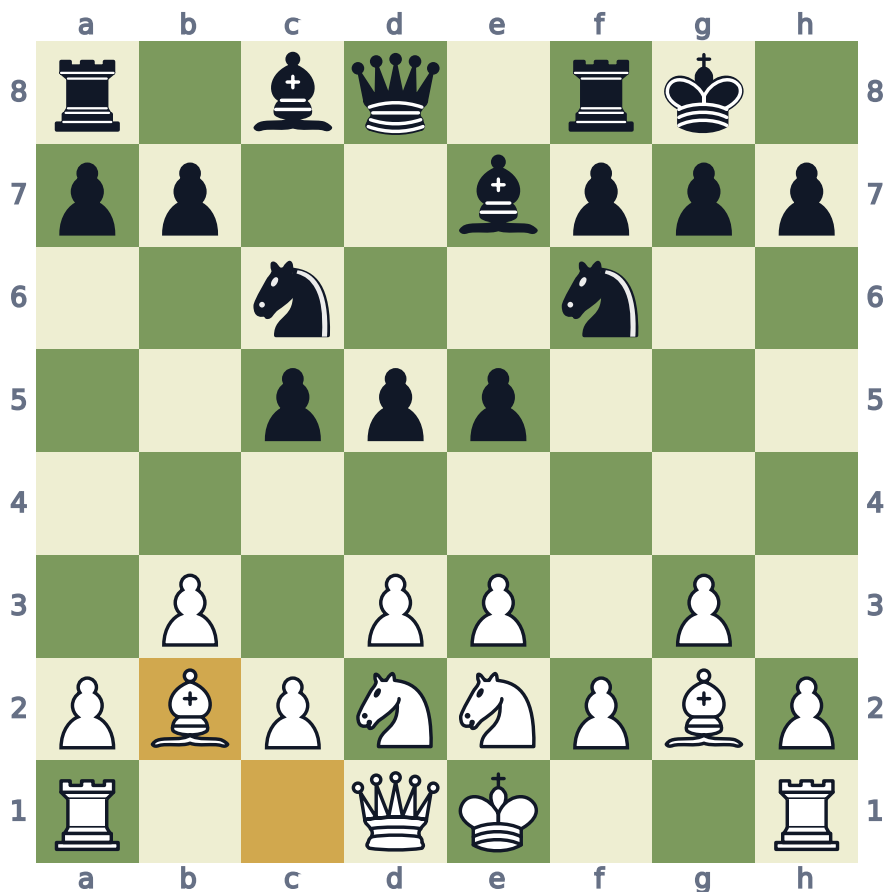
1. Be3 Bg4 2. Bf2 Qxd1+ 3. Rxd1 Bxf3 4. gxf3 Rfd8 5. Bd3 e6 (+0.11 for White (equal))

TRANSFER CUE

When e5 cramps both knights, the setup phase is over.

STRUCTURE 28 OF 30

White Hippo vs classical center



COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Complete the flexible shell, then challenge the center with e4 or c4.

OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

Black can gain too much space if White keeps waiting.

ENGINE SAMPLE

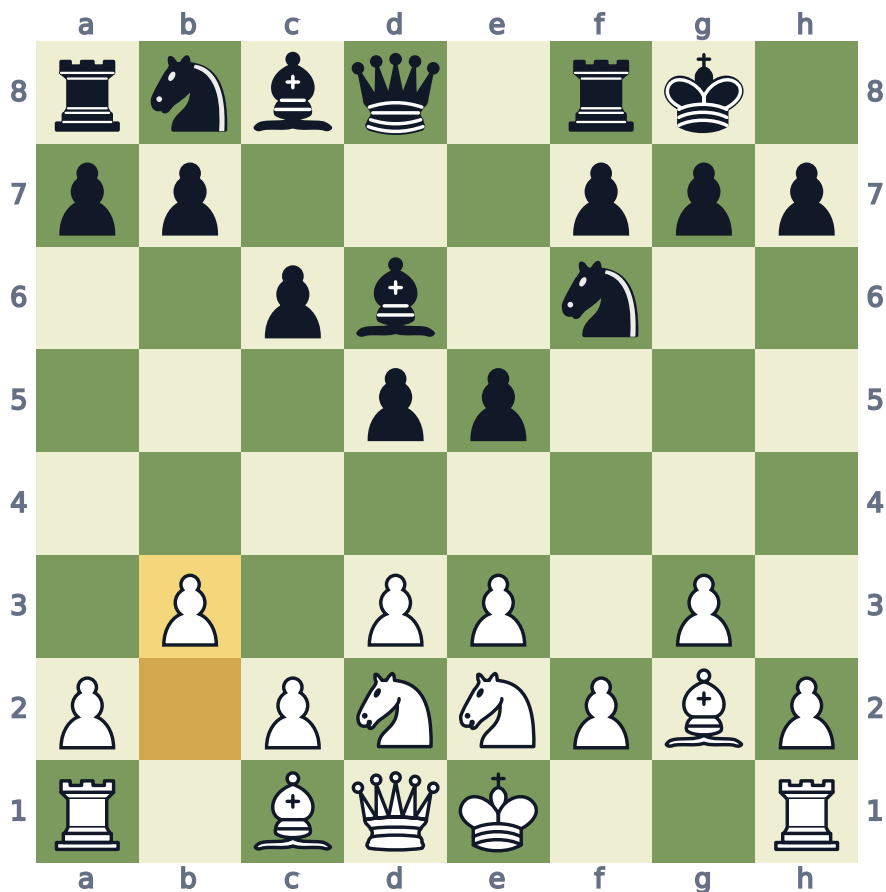
1. Be6 O-O 2. Re8 d4 3. cxd4 exd4 4. e4 c4 (-0.61 for White (Black is slightly better))

TRANSFER CUE

The extra tempo must become central contact.

STRUCTURE 29 OF 30

White Hippo vs e5-d5



COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Prepare Bb2 and choose e4 or c4 based on Black's support.

OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

f5 can start a kingside attack before White is coordinated.

ENGINE SAMPLE

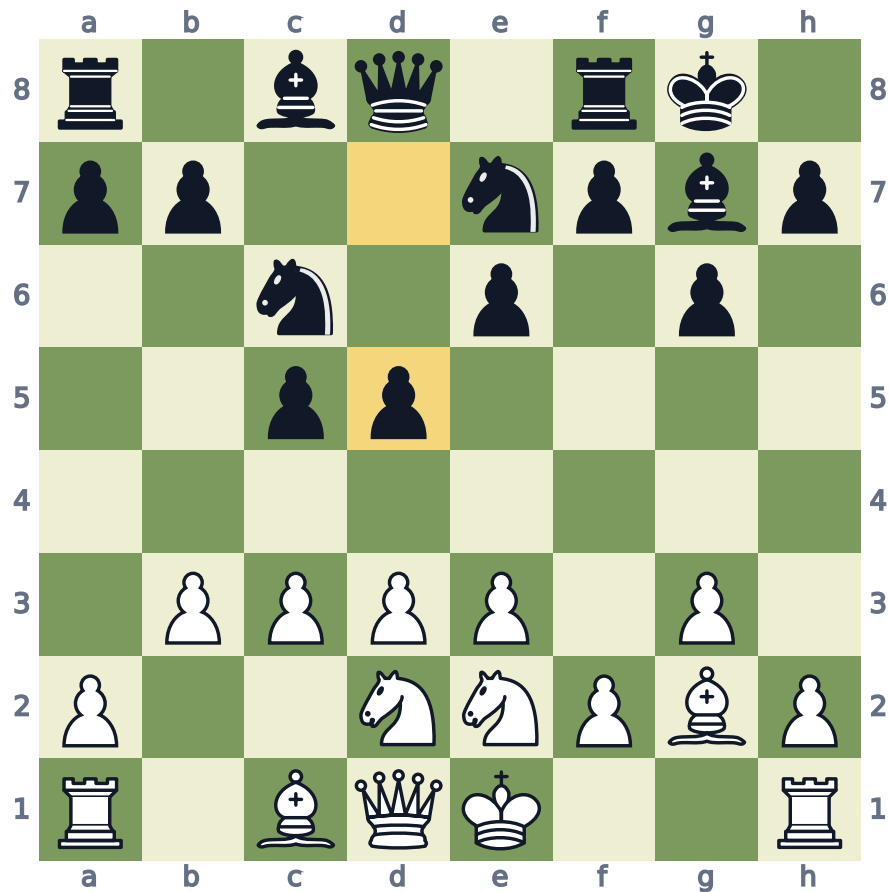
1. a5 O-O 2. Re8 a3 3. b5 c4 4. h6 Qc2 5. Bf5 Bb2 (-0.82 for White (Black is clearly better))

TRANSFER CUE

Against a full center, identify its weaker base before completing every setup move.

STRUCTURE 30 OF 30

White Hippo vs Sicilian setup



COURSE-SIDE PLAN

Use c3 to close the long diagonal, then choose e4 or d4 to contest the center.

OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

Black may play d5 in one move and equalize comfortably.

ENGINE SAMPLE

1. O-O e5 2. a4 b6 3. Ba3 a5 4. d4 cxd4 5. exd4 e4 (-0.48 for White (Black is slightly better))

TRANSFER CUE

Before b3 exposes a1, place a pawn on c3 or move the rook.

VOLUME REVIEW

Make the repertoire usable

REVIEW TASK 1

Reconstruct every branch from the first move without looking.

REVIEW TASK 2

For each branch, explain one Black plan and one White plan.

REVIEW TASK 3

Shuffle the recall positions so the chapter title cannot reveal the answer.

REVIEW TASK 4

Play each starting position against Fritz from both sides.

REVIEW TASK 5

Add mistakes from your own games to the PGN as new training positions.

REVIEW TASK 6

Retest the weakest three branches after 1, 3, 7, 14, 30, and 60 days.

GRADUATION STANDARD

Score at least 80 percent twice, one week apart, and explain every move in plain language. Then maintain the volume through your own games instead of rereading it continuously.